

Module 07: Communication — Sharing Presence Across Bodies

Learning Objectives

1. Define **communication** as the alignment of generative models between embodied agents, mediated by both verbal and non-verbal channels of present-moment exchange.
2. Explain how **interpersonal synchrony** (respiratory coupling, postural mirroring, affective resonance) constitutes a form of active inference across shared Markov blankets.
3. Analyze the role of **contemplative dialogue** practices (Insight Dialogue, council, authentic relating) as systematic methods for minimizing interpersonal free energy through embodied presence.
4. Apply the concept of **social affordances** to understand how living presence transforms the quality and depth of human connection.

Introduction

When you sit in silent meditation with another person, something unexpected happens. Without words, without deliberate coordination, your breathing begins to synchronize. A warmth arises in the space between you. The quality of your attention shifts — it is no longer purely inward but participatory, as though your awareness has expanded to include the other's presence. This non-verbal communion is not metaphor. It is the measurable alignment of two generative models through shared sensory channels — respiratory rhythm, postural resonance, autonomic coupling — minimizing interpersonal free energy without a single word being spoken.

Communication, in the context of living presence, extends far beyond the transmission of information from sender to receiver. The enactive tradition, following Ezequiel Di Paolo and Hanne De Jaegher (2012), reconceives communication as **participatory sense-making** — the joint creation of meaning through embodied interaction. Two organisms do not merely exchange signals; they co-constitute a shared domain of significance through their ongoing

coupling. Active inference formalizes this insight: communication is the process by which two or more generative models come into alignment, reducing mutual prediction error through coordinated action and shared attention.

Key Concepts

1. Interpersonal Synchrony and Coupled Inference

Research in social neuroscience has documented extensive interpersonal synchrony between interacting humans. Conversation partners spontaneously synchronize their posture, gesture timing, vocal prosody, and even physiological rhythms (heart rate, skin conductance, respiratory phase). From an active inference perspective, this synchrony reflects coupled inference: each person's generative model is predicting not only their own bodily states but also the other's behavior. When these mutual predictions align, free energy is minimized across the dyad, producing the subjective experience of rapport, attunement, and connection.

Uri Hasson and colleagues have shown that during engaged storytelling, the listener's brain activity becomes temporally coupled with the speaker's — neural synchrony that increases with comprehension and engagement. This "brain-to-brain coupling" is the neural signature of aligned generative models, and it is strongest when both participants are fully present and attentive.

2. The Shared Markov Blanket

In active inference, communication can be understood through the concept of a **shared Markov blanket** — a statistical boundary that encompasses not one but two (or more) interacting agents. When two people engage in genuine dialogue, the boundary between their generative models becomes partially permeable. Sensory states that were previously external to each agent's blanket become shared: your facial expression becomes part of my sensory evidence, and my postural shifts become part of yours. The shared blanket creates a coupled system in which free energy is minimized jointly rather than independently.

Thomas Fuchs and Hanne De Jaegher (2009) describe this as **mutual incorporation** — the process by which another person's body becomes an extension of one's own experiential field. In present-centered communication, I do not merely observe your gestures from outside; I feel

them resonating in my own body through mirror neuron activation and affective attunement. Communication, at its deepest, is the partial merging of two embodied generative models.

3. Contemplative Dialogue and Mindful Speech

Gregory Kramer's **Insight Dialogue** practice offers a systematic method for bringing contemplative awareness into interpersonal exchange. The practice is structured around six guidelines: pause, relax, open, trust emergence, listen deeply, and speak the truth. Each guideline can be understood in active inference terms. "Pause" interrupts habitual communication patterns, creating space for the generative model to reset. "Relax" reduces excessive precision on social anxiety signals. "Open" expands the sensory field to include the other's full embodied presence. "Listen deeply" increases precision on the other's verbal and non-verbal signals. "Speak the truth" reduces the divergence between the internal model and its external expression.

When practitioners communicate from this state of embodied presence, the quality of exchange transforms. Words arise more slowly, from a somatic source rather than from rehearsed scripts. Listening becomes full-body receptivity rather than cognitive processing. The result is communication that minimizes free energy not through efficiency but through authenticity — the alignment of what is felt, what is expressed, and what is received.

4. Non-Verbal Communication and Somatic Resonance

The vast majority of interpersonal communication is non-verbal — conveyed through facial expression, tone of voice, gesture, posture, proximity, and touch. These channels operate largely beneath conscious awareness, transmitting information about emotional state, intention, and relational quality through the body's own signaling systems. In active inference, non-verbal communication is the primary channel through which generative models achieve alignment, because it operates at the fast, automatic timescales of embodied prediction rather than the slower timescales of linguistic processing.

Somatic resonance — the felt sense of another person's emotional state in one's own body — is a particularly direct form of non-verbal communication. When you feel a tightening in your chest while sitting with someone who is anxious, your generative model is predicting your own interoceptive states based on the sensory evidence provided by the other's body. This

resonance is the embodied foundation of empathy, and it is most pronounced when both participants are in a state of present-moment awareness.

Active Inference Connection

Communication through living presence reveals the fundamentally social nature of active inference. Organisms do not minimize free energy in isolation; they are embedded in webs of interpersonal coupling that shape their generative models from birth. The infant's earliest communications — the rhythmic exchange of gaze, vocalization, and touch with the caregiver — establish the templates for all subsequent social inference. Present-centered communication practices recapitulate and deepen these early patterns, creating conditions in which generative models can align with unusual depth and authenticity. Free energy is minimized not only within individuals but across the coupled system of communicating bodies.

Experiential Applications

- **Practice — Silent Sitting with a Partner:** Sit facing another person at a comfortable distance, eyes gently open. Make no effort to communicate — simply be present with your own embodied experience while remaining aware of the other's presence. After five minutes, notice what has shifted: Has your breathing changed? Do you feel the other's presence in your body? Where? This practice cultivates awareness of the non-verbal channels through which generative models spontaneously align.
- **Case Study — Therapeutic Alliance and Treatment Outcomes:** Research consistently shows that the quality of the therapeutic alliance — the felt sense of connection between therapist and client — is the strongest predictor of treatment outcomes, regardless of therapeutic modality. From an active inference perspective, the therapeutic alliance is the establishment of a shared Markov blanket in which the client's generative model can be safely explored and updated. The therapist's embodied presence — calm autonomic regulation, attuned facial expression, responsive postural shifts — provides a stable predictive environment in which the client's model can relax its defensive precision settings and become open to new evidence.

Cross-References

- **Module 06 (Learning):** The learning that occurs through communication — the reshaping of social generative models through interpersonal practice.
- **Module 08 (Planning):** Planning in social contexts draws on the communicative alignment explored here.
- **Unit 01 (Felt Sense):** The interoceptive foundation that enables somatic resonance and empathic communication.
- **Unit 04 (Moving Through World):** Extends embodied communication into shared movement practices — partner dance, contact improvisation, ensemble performance.

Summary

Communication in the context of living presence is the embodied alignment of generative models across interacting agents. Through interpersonal synchrony, shared Markov blankets, contemplative dialogue, and non-verbal somatic resonance, communicating bodies minimize free energy jointly rather than in isolation. The enactive concept of participatory sense-making reveals communication not as information transfer but as the co-creation of meaning through embodied coupling. Present-centered communication practices — from silent sitting with a partner to Insight Dialogue — cultivate the depth of attunement and authenticity that transforms mere exchange into genuine meeting. To communicate with full presence is to allow the boundaries between self and other to become, for a time, transparent — two generative models resonating as one.